What the Water Keeps

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Prologue: The Valley of Vell

The valley of Vell lies in the fold of two mountains that the old maps call the Sisters, though no one in Vell has ever called them anything but the Left One and the Right One. It is eleven kilometres long and never more than two across. The river Vell runs through it without hurry, because it has nowhere particular to be.

The first people to settle there were shepherds who came up from the coast in the fourteenth century, driving their flocks away from a plague. They stayed because the grass was good and because no one followed them. By 1600 there were four hamlets: Vell Alto, Vell Baixo, the Mill, and a scatter of houses around the church of Saint Anselm that was never given a name of its own and so was called, simply, the Church.

The church was built in 1611 with stone carried from the Right One on the backs of mules. Its bell was cast in 1702 in the city and brought up the valley on a cart that broke two axles on the way. The bell weighed six hundred kilograms and had a crack in its lip from the second axle, which gave it a flat, sorrowful note that the people of Vell considered the correct sound for a bell.

In 1880 the river flooded. The water came up to the church door and stayed for nine days. Eleven people drowned, among them the priest. When the water went down, the villagers found that the bell, which no one had been able to reach to ring, had rung by itself on the ninth night. Some said it was the wind. Some said it was the priest.

In the twentieth century, the valley emptied slowly. The young went down to the coast and to the city and did not come back, except for funerals. By 1950 there were one hundred and forty people in Vell. By 1956, when the Ministry of Waters announced that a dam would be built at the mouth of the valley, there were ninety-one.

The dam was to be called the Sisters Dam. The reservoir behind it would cover all four hamlets, the church, the mill, and eleven kilometres of river. The Ministry said it would bring electricity to three hundred

thousand homes. The Ministry sent letters to all ninety-one people explaining the compensation they would receive, which was calculated by the hectare and by the height of each property above the river.

To calculate the height of each property above the river, the Ministry needed a survey. To make the survey, in the spring of 1957, it sent Ines Maro.

Chapter One

Ines arrived in Vell on the fourteenth of April with a theodolite, a levelling staff, two tripods, a case of drawing instruments, and a suitcase that contained, in its entirety, the rest of her life.

The bus left her at the bridge in Vell Baixo because it did not go further. She stood on the bridge with her equipment around her like luggage at a station and looked up the valley. It was greener than the maps had told her. Maps never told you the colour of anything.

The post office was the first building past the bridge. A woman in a grey cardigan came out of it and stood with her arms folded, looking at the tripods.

"You'll be the surveyor," she said.

"Ines Maro. From the Ministry."

"Odile Farre. Postmistress. I also keep the telephone, the register of deaths, and the key to the church, so if you want anything in this valley that isn't a sheep, you'll be wanting me." She looked at the theodolite. "They said a surveyor. They didn't say a girl."

"I'm twenty-nine."

"That's what I said."

Odile carried the levelling staff up the hill to the inn, because she said she would not have it said that Vell had let a Ministry woman carry her own staff. On the way she told Ines everything. The dam would close its gates at the end of September. Forty-three families had already signed. Thirty-one were arguing about the money. Sixteen had not answered the letters at all, and one had burned his.

"Who burned his?"

"Tomas Aurelio. The beekeeper. He has the ferry, too, at the narrows, though there's no one to ferry any more." Odile shifted the staff to her other shoulder. "He'll not sign. His grandmother's grandmother is under the church floor. You'll be wanting to survey his land, and he'll not let you, and I'm telling you now so you'll not say no one told you."

The inn had six rooms and one guest. Ines took the room at the top because it had a window facing up the valley. She unpacked the suitcase in four minutes. She unpacked the instruments in forty, cleaning each one, the way her father had taught her, so that the valley would know she had come to measure it properly.

Chapter Two

She found the ferry on her third day, when she had already set stakes along the lower meadows and was working upstream toward the narrows.

It was a flat boat on a rope strung across the river where the valley pinched. On the far bank, rows of white hives stood in a slope of wild thyme like a small, orderly town. A man was among them, veiled, moving slowly. When he saw her he did not stop moving slowly.

She waited. She had learned to wait for landowners. After a quarter of an hour he came down to the water, took off the veil, and looked at her across the river. He was perhaps thirty-five. He had the face of a man who had been told a great many things by officials and had believed none of them.

"The Ministry," he said.

"I need to measure the height of your land above the river. For the compensation."

"I know what for."

"It will take two days. I won't disturb the hives."

"You'll disturb them by being here. They know when something is being counted." He pulled the ferry rope once, idly, so the boat bumped the bank. "What do you do with it, when you've measured it?"

"I draw it. The Ministry sets the compensation from the drawing."

"And then they drown it."

"Yes."

He seemed surprised she had not argued. He looked at her for a long moment. "At least you don't lie," he said. "The last one lied. He said the lake would be beautiful."

"It probably will be."

"So is a grave, if you keep it tidy."

She set her stakes on his side of the river the next morning, having rowed herself across on the ferry while he was up among the hives. When she came back the following morning, the stakes were gone. They were lying in a neat pile on the ferry, with a jar of honey on top of them.

She set them again. The next morning they were in a pile again, with a second jar.

On the fourth morning she did not set the stakes. She sat on the bank with the two jars of honey and waited until he came down.

"I can make the survey without your land," she said. "I'll estimate it from the other side. The estimate will be low. They always are. You'll be paid for land ten metres lower than it is."

"Then they'll have paid me less to drown more."

"Yes."

"You're a strange sort of Ministry."

"I'm a surveyor. The Ministry is in the city."

He sat down on the bank, a little way from her, and looked at the water. "Two days," he said finally. "And you'll write down the names."

"What names?"

"Of the fields. Everything here has a name. The Ministry map has numbers." He stood up. "If you want my land, you take the names with it."

Chapter Three

That night, in the room at the top of the inn, Ines could not sleep, and she thought about her father.

Her father had been a cartographer for the army, and then, after the war, for no one in particular. He had drawn maps of places that did not need maps: the allotments behind their building in the city, the route of the number nine tram, the inside of their apartment, which he drew once at a scale of one to twenty so that Ines, who was seven, could see that her bed was exactly the length of the kitchen table. He had believed that a place drawn carefully was a place that could not entirely disappear. "A map is a promise," he had told her, when she was old enough to hold a pen steadily, "that the place will still be there when you come back. Even if it isn't."

She had not understood the second half until he died. After the funeral, she had taken out his map of the apartment, the one at one to twenty, and found that it was more real to her than the apartment itself, which had already been let to another family. The map remembered where the sofa had been. The map remembered the crack in the hall floor where she had lost a tooth. The map did not know he was dead.

She thought about the Ministry map of Vell, which she was making. It had numbers for fields. It had contour lines at five-metre intervals. It had, in a box in the lower corner, the projected water level of the reservoir, a single blue line at four hundred and twelve metres. Everything below the blue line would be compensated and then removed from all future maps. The valley would become a shape of blue with no names in it.

She thought about the beekeeper saying "you'll write down the names", as if he knew what her father had known. She thought that he was probably only being difficult. She thought that it did not matter why he had said it. She thought that she would do it anyway, and that no one at the Ministry would ever look at the names, because no one at the Ministry ever looked at anything except the blue line.

She got up at four and wrote, in the margin of her field book, in very small letters: *Names. Ask him every name.* Then she slept until seven, and dreamed of nothing.

Chapter Four

On Monday there was a letter from her brother.

Paulo was twenty-four and lived in the city in a room above a tailor's. He had been, at various times, a clerk, a bicycle messenger, a singer in a café, and a man who was about to go into business. The letter was four pages long and said, on the fourth page, that he owed a man called Rufio eleven hundred escudos from cards and that Rufio was not a patient person. It did not ask for money. It said, "I'm only telling you so you'll know, if anything happens." This was how Paulo asked for money.

Ines read the letter twice, standing at the post office counter, while Odile pretended not to read it upside down.

"Family?" said Odile.

"My brother."

"Trouble?"

"Always."

She folded the letter and put it in her field book, and then she put it out of her mind, because there was nothing she could do about Paulo from Vell, and because she had learned a long time ago that Paulo's trouble was weather: it came, it went, it was never anyone's fault.

That afternoon a young man in a Ministry jacket came up the valley on a motorcycle. His name was Bento Lusa and he was the clerk to the chief engineer of the Sisters Dam. He found Ines at the mill, where she was taking levels, and explained, without taking off his gloves, that the schedule had changed. The concrete had cured faster than predicted. The gates would close not at the end of September but on the first of September. The survey must be complete, drawn, and delivered to the engineer's office by the fifteenth of August.

"That's four months of work in three," said Ines.

"The engineer is aware."

"Is the engineer aware that the valley is eleven kilometres long?"

"The engineer has a map," said Bento, and seemed to think this was an answer.

He also told her that the compensation board would use her heights to settle the disputed claims, and that the board was, as he put it, "anxious that heights not be overstated." Several landowners, he said, had been moving boundary stones.

"I measure the ground," said Ines. "I don't measure the stones."

"Of course," said Bento. He looked around the mill with the expression of a man pricing it. "Beautiful old place. Shame." Then he got back on his motorcycle and went back down the valley.

Chapter Five

The storm came on the last day of April, out of a clear afternoon, the way storms came in Vell, Odile said, because the mountains hid them until it was too late.

Ines was on the far bank at the narrows, working alone, when the rain arrived like something thrown. She got the theodolite off its tripod and ran for the ferry. The river had already risen and was brown and fast. Halfway across, the ferry rope jerked, the boat tipped, and the theodolite case went over the side.

She did not think. She went in after it.

The water was so cold it felt like being struck. She got a hand on the case and the current took her and the case together, and then something took her collar and hauled, and she was on the bank on her back in the thyme with Tomas Aurelio kneeling beside her, soaked, furious, holding the theodolite case in his other hand.

"For a box," he said. "You went in for a box."

"It's the only one," she said, and started to shake.

His house was a stone cottage above the hives. He put her by the fire in a blanket that smelled of wax and smoke and hung her clothes over a chair and did not look at her while he did it. He opened the theodolite case on the table and took out the instrument and dried it with a cloth, part by part, the way she would have done. She watched him from inside the blanket.

"My father made clocks," he said, without turning around. "Before the bees. You take care of a thing that measures."

When the rain stopped, near midnight, he walked her not to the ferry but up the slope behind the house, to the church. It stood alone on a rise above the river, and it would be, by the Ministry's blue line, eighteen metres under water. He had the key. Odile, he said, had given it to him years ago and forgotten.

Inside it was dark and smelled of old stone. He lit a candle and led her up the tower stairs, and at the top there was the bell, enormous, green-black, with the crack in its lip.

"My grandmother told me about this bell," he said, "every night of my life until I was twelve."

And he told her, sitting on the top step of the tower with the candle between them, the story as his grandmother Zelia had told it: how in the flood of 1880 the water had come to the church door and would not go down; how the priest, Father Anselmo, who was named for the saint, had stayed in the church to keep the candles lit and had drowned there on the fourth night; how the village had stood on the Left One and watched the water for nine days and nights; how on the ninth night, with no wind at all, the bell had rung once, one long flat cracked note that went all the way up the valley and back; and how in the morning the water had begun to go down.

"She said that when the valley is full," he said, "the bell will ring once more. For whoever it belongs to."

"Who does it belong to?"

"She never said. I asked her every night. She said I'd know when I heard it." He looked at the bell. "I think she didn't know either."

Ines looked at the crack in the bell's lip. She thought of the blue line on her map at four hundred and twelve metres, and of the tower, and of the eighteen metres of water. She did not say anything. He seemed grateful.

Chapter Six

After the storm, he helped her.

He came every morning at six to the ferry with a flask of coffee and walked the valley with her, carrying the staff, holding it plumb, reading the heights back to her in a voice that carried across meadows. And he named everything. The field below the mill was the Widow's Piece, because a widow had farmed it alone for forty years. The spring above Vell Alto was Anselmo's Eye. The bend in the river where the trout lay was Little Lisbon, for no reason anyone remembered. The slope of the hives was Thyme Hill, and the rock at the top of it, shaped like a sleeping dog, was the Dog.

Ines wrote every name on the working map in pencil, in small capitals, beside the Ministry's numbers. Parcel 114 became THE WIDOW'S PIECE. Parcel 212 became THYME HILL. After a month the map was so full of names that the numbers looked like an afterthought.

"They'll rub those out," said Tomas once, looking over her shoulder.

"They won't look at them."

"Then why write them?"

"Because you asked."

He did not answer that, but he stood closer to her for the rest of the afternoon, close enough that when she bent over the theodolite she could feel him not touching her, which was a different thing from being alone.

On the last Saturday in June, the village held the Night of Lanterns. It was an old festival, older than the church. Every family made a paper lantern with a candle inside and set it on the river at dusk at the top of the valley, and the lanterns floated all the way down to the bridge, eleven kilometres, and the children ran beside them on the banks. This year everyone knew it was the last one. Even the families who had already signed and moved to the coast came back for it.

Tomas made a lantern for Ines. It was white paper, and on it, in careful capitals copied from her map, he had written all the names.

They set it on the water together at the top of the valley. They walked beside it in the dark as far as the narrows, among the other walkers and the running children, and at the narrows, where the lanterns bunched and spun in the current, she turned to say something, and he was already looking at her, and she forgot what it had been.

Later, she could never remember who had moved first. She remembered the lanterns going on without them, down toward the bridge, and that the names on hers had caught the light.

Chapter Seven

In July there was a second letter from Paulo. Rufio had become impatient. Paulo had moved rooms. He did not say where. He said he was fine. He said, in a postscript, that he had been thinking of their father, and that their father would have known what to do.

Ines sent him her savings, which were nine hundred and forty escudos, by postal order from Odile's counter. Odile stamped the order without comment, and then, after Ines had gone, rang the inn and told the innkeeper to give the surveyor a proper supper for once, since she clearly wasn't going to buy one.

The money reached Paulo. He wrote back a postcard with a picture of the harbour: *Saved. You are a saint. I will pay you back by Christmas.* Ines put the postcard in her field book with the other letters, and did not think about it again until much later, when it had long since stopped mattering.

Chapter Eight

On the second of August, Ines finished the heights for Thyme Hill and sat down at her table at the inn to draw them. She worked until two in the morning. When she was finished, she sat for a long time looking at the drawing.

Tomas's house stood at four hundred and nine metres. His hives stood between four hundred and six and four hundred and fourteen. The Dog, at the top of the slope, stood at four hundred and nineteen.

The blue line was at four hundred and twelve.

Under the rules of the compensation board, land entirely below the waterline was paid in full. Land that was partly above it was classed as "residual" and paid at a third, on the grounds that the owner could go on using what was left. If the heights were as she had measured them, Tomas's land was residual. He would be paid a third. He would be left with a strip of thyme and a rock shaped like a dog and a lake where his house had been.

She measured it again the next day, alone, at dawn, three times. The heights were correct. She had known they would be.

Bento came up the valley on the fifth to collect the drawings early. He sat at the inn table and turned the pages without interest until he came to Thyme Hill, and then he stopped and smiled.

"Residual," he said. "Good. The board will be pleased. Aurelio's the loudest of them." He looked at the pencilled names in the margins. "What's all this?"

"Local names."

"We'll clean that up in the drawing office." He closed the folder. "You're very thorough, Miss Maro."

Tomas came to the inn that evening. Someone had told him; in Vell someone always told everyone. He stood in the doorway of her room and did not come in.

"A third," he said.

"The heights are the heights. I measured them three times."

"You could have measured them once, badly."

"Yes."

"Everyone else lies to me," he said. "I thought that was the worst thing. I was wrong. You're worse. You tell me the truth and you let it happen."

"If I had changed the numbers, the next surveyor would have found it and the board would have thrown out your whole claim. And mine with it. And every claim I've drawn in this valley."

"So you did it for them."

"I did it because it's true."

He looked at the map on the table, at THYME HILL in her small capitals. "Rub out the names," he said. "They're not yours."

He went down the stairs. She heard the inn door, and then nothing, and then, a long time later, the ferry rope creaking across the river in the dark.

Chapter Nine

On the first of September, at noon, the gates of the Sisters Dam closed, and the water began to rise.

It rose slowly at first, a finger's width an hour, so that it was possible to watch a stone at the river's edge for an afternoon and see it disappear. Then faster. The mill wheel went under on the third day. The bridge at Vell Baixo went under on the fifth, and the bus stopped coming. Families left in carts and trucks and on foot, carrying chairs, carrying clocks, carrying an old woman in a wheelbarrow who refused to be carried any other way. Odile closed the post office on the sixth, took the register of deaths under her arm, and moved into the inn, which was on high ground and would survive as a café for fishermen.

Ines should have left with the surveyors' truck on the fourth. She told the driver she had drawings to finish. She had no drawings to finish.

She thought about the church. She thought about the eighteen metres. She thought about the fact that she had not seen Tomas in a month, and that the ferry had not moved since the gates closed, and that the smoke from his chimney was still going up every morning from the slope above the hives, a thin grey line against the Right One. She thought that there are people who leave a place, and people who let a place leave them, and that she had always been the first kind and had always assumed that everyone was, if you gave them long enough. She thought she might have been wrong.

On the eighth, Odile found her at the window of the inn and stood beside her looking at the smoke.

"He's moved his bees," Odile said. "Up to the high pasture, on the Dog. Took him three nights. Carried every hive himself."

"Then he's leaving."

"He's moved his bees," Odile said. "He hasn't moved himself. Old Belmiro saw him going up to the church yesterday with blankets." She was quiet for a moment. "His grandmother's grandmother is under that

floor. I told you that the day you came. You'll not say no one told you."

Chapter Ten

The water reached the church door on the eleventh of September.

Ines took the inn's rowing boat at dusk. The valley was a lake now at the lower end, grey and flat and full of the tops of trees, and she rowed up it over the drowned meadows, over the Widow's Piece and over Little Lisbon, which she knew only because she had measured them. The church stood up out of the water on its rise like a ship. The door was under. She tied the boat to a window grille of the tower and climbed in.

He was at the top of the tower, sitting against the wall beside the bell, with a blanket and a lamp and a jar of honey. He did not look surprised.

"Go back," he said. "It's rising a metre a day."

"I know. I measured it."

"Then you know how long I have."

"Six days before it reaches this floor. Eight before the bell." She sat down on the top step, where she had sat in April. "I brought you something."

She took the map out of its oilcloth tube and unrolled it on the stone between them, holding the corners down with the lamp and the honey jar and her two hands. It was not the working map. It was the final Ministry drawing, the one on linen, the one with the engineer's stamp in the corner: VALLEY OF VELL, SISTERS RESERVOIR, ARCHIVE COPY. And on it, beside every number, in black ink, in small, careful, permanent capitals, were the names. THE WIDOW'S PIECE. ANSELMO'S EYE. LITTLE LISBON. THYME HILL. THE DOG.

"They took them off," she said. "In the drawing office. So I put them back. Last week, in the archive, at night. I told the archivist I'd found an error in the contours." She touched the linen. "This is the one they keep. Forever. It's the only copy that matters. They'll never look at it again. But it will be there."

He looked at the map for a long time.

"A map is a promise," she said. "That the place will still be there when you come back. Even if it isn't. My father told me that."

"And the bell?"

"Your grandmother didn't know who it belonged to. Maybe it doesn't belong to anyone. Maybe it just rings."

He looked at her then. "You went in for the box," he said. "In April. I thought you were a fool."

"I was."

"So am I," he said, and rolled up the map.

They rowed away from the tower in the dark with the lamp in the bow. The water was so still that the church stood in it twice, once upward, once down. They were halfway to the inn when they heard it: one long, flat, cracked note, carried over the water from the tower behind them, all the way up the valley and back.

There was no wind at all.

Neither of them said anything. Tomas stopped rowing and they sat in the boat and listened until there was nothing left to listen to.

Chapter Eleven

She left Vell on the fifteenth of September with the surveyors' last truck.

He did not come with her. They had both known he would not. He had the bees on the Dog, above the waterline, on the strip of land the Ministry had paid a third for; he had built a hut beside the hives out of the stones of his old garden wall, carried up the slope one at a time. He said the bees would not understand the city. He said he would not either. She did not argue, because she had never argued with the truth, and because she understood that some people let a place leave them and some people stay with what is left.

At the edge of the new lake, he gave her a jar of honey. She gave him the working map, the one in pencil, with the names in small capitals and her coffee rings in the corners.

"Come back," he said.

"There's nothing to come back to."

"There's the Dog," he said. "And the thyme. And the names."

In the city, Paulo did not pay her back by Christmas, or ever, and was, when she found him, perfectly well and about to go into business. She was assigned to survey a railway in the south, and then a harbour, and then the extension of the number nine tram. She drew them all carefully. She wrote the local names in the margins of every map, in pencil, knowing they would be rubbed out, and wrote them again in ink on the archive copies, at night, when no one was looking.

Every year, in June, a jar of honey arrived at her office with no letter. It tasted of thyme.

Many years later, walking home through the old quarter on a winter evening, Ines heard a bell ring once from a church she did not know: one long, flat note, a little cracked, that went up the street and back. She stopped on the pavement and stood there, with people going around her, until there was nothing left to listen to. Then she went home and took

out a clean sheet of paper and began, at a scale of one to twenty, to draw a valley.